False Exit

Level Design Document

Linear single-player horror level

Level Type	Linear single-player horror / chase level
Core Fantasy	Run through a hostile maze, survive hazards, and find the real exit before the monster catches you.
Prototype Goal	Deliver a short, tense level that is readable, fair, and memorable in 3-5 minutes of play.

1. Game Summary

False Exit is a linear horror level built around pressure, navigation, and false choices. The player wakes up in a red-lit maze, is pushed forward by a pursuing monster, and must dodge moving hazards while searching for the real exit among several fake ones. The level is designed to feel tense, unfair at first glance, but actually readable once the player understands the logic of the space.

2. Level Intention

The main intention of this level is to create controlled panic. The player should feel hunted, should doubt the environment, and should make fast movement decisions under pressure. At the same time, the level should stay clear enough that failure feels like a player mistake, not broken design.

3. Concept

Requirements

- The player must understand the main objective quickly: escape the maze.
- The monster must appear and create constant pressure across the level.
- The player must face moving, falling, or rising hazards that force dodging and route choices.
- The player must encounter at least two fake exits before the real exit.
- The player must reach the real exit to finish the level and transition to Level 2.

Goals

- The level should create strong tension, confusion, and urgency from start to finish.
- The level should remain readable through landmarks, light, and route logic.
- The player should feel that the environment is hostile but still learnable.
- The final escape should feel earned and satisfying, not random.

Game Context

This is the opening major level of the False Exit prototype. It introduces the game's horror tone, the fake-exit mechanic, and the idea that the environment itself can lie to the player. Completing this level leads into a second level focused on breaking and moving floors.

Setting

The level takes place inside a red-lit liminal maze with industrial details, warning lights, repeating corridors, dirty walls, broken props, and distorted EXIT signs. The visual style should feel familiar enough to read quickly, but wrong enough to feel dangerous.

Time

The level is set in an enclosed interior with no natural daylight. The feeling is permanent artificial night.

Metrics

- Prototype target playtime: 3-5 minutes on a first successful run.
- Corridors stay narrow enough to create pressure, but wide enough for readable dodge movement.
- Hazard timing must allow reaction, not prediction-only play.
- The player should always be within one clear decision of the next meaningful space.

4. Narrative & Drama

Beat Chart

The level uses rising pressure, false relief, and a short final release.

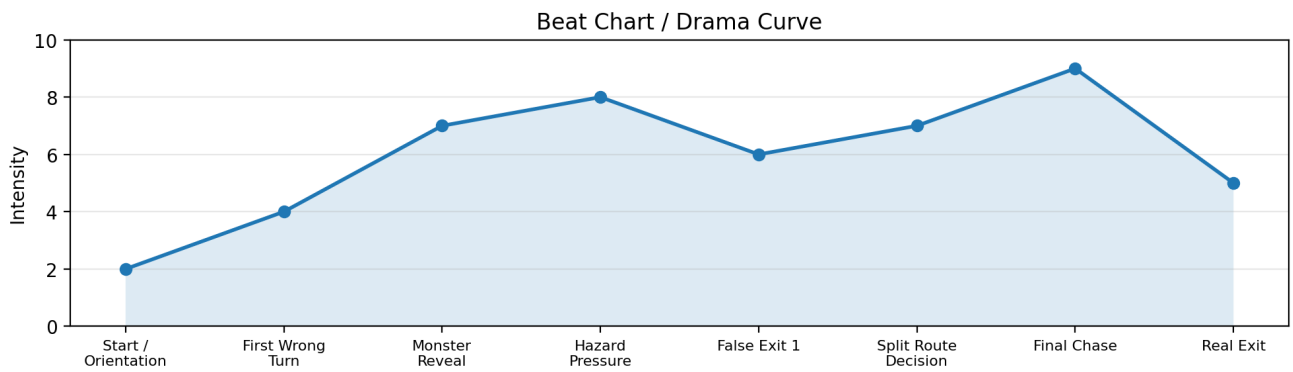

Figure 1. Beat chart / drama curve for False Exit.

Explicit Narrative

- The player understands they are trapped and must escape.
- The monster is presented as an active threat, not a background story element.
- Fake exits teach the player that visual promises in the level cannot be trusted.

Implicit Narrative

- Repeated exit signs and broken hallways imply a place designed to mislead or punish people trying to leave.

- Environmental damage, alarm lighting, and fallen props suggest prior failed escape attempts.
- The red emergency lighting makes the whole level feel like a system already in collapse.

Dialogue / Script Notes

There is no spoken dialogue in this level. Narrative is carried through environment, pacing, signage, and the player's survival experience.

Emotional Target

The level should move the player through four clear feelings: curiosity, discomfort, pressure, and relief. Curiosity pulls the player in, discomfort makes them doubt the space, pressure comes from the monster and hazards, and relief only arrives at the real exit.

5. Mapping

Pathing Diagram

The level uses one clear golden path, but lets the player branch into misleading routes long enough to create tension and loss of confidence.

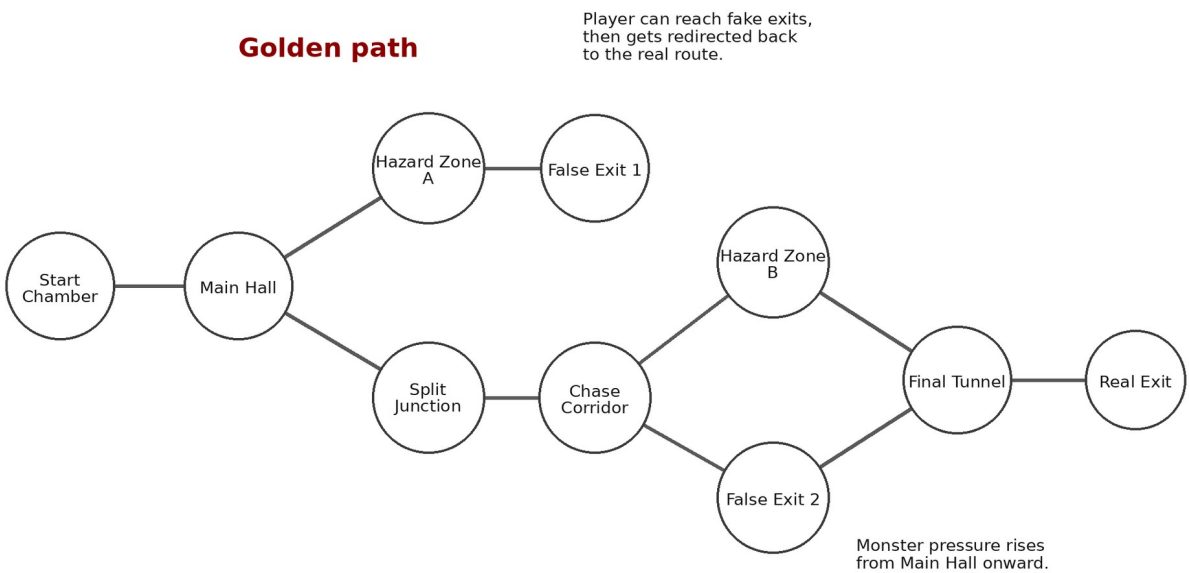

Figure 2. Pathing diagram with fake exits and rejoin points.

Landmarks

Scale	Landmark	Purpose
Macro	Main Hall	First readable anchor after the start; tells the player the level is larger than one corridor.
Meso	Red warning junction	Signals a key route change and raises intensity before the first fake exit.

Meso	Chase Corridor	The strongest pressure space; visually narrower and more aggressive.
Micro	False Exit doors	Short-term reward markers that deliberately betray player expectation.
Macro	Real Exit door	Final payoff landmark; cleaner silhouette and stronger contrast than fake exits.

Level Map

The map below shows the intended top-down prototype layout. It is not a final art blueprint; it is a design map focused on flow, danger, and decision points.

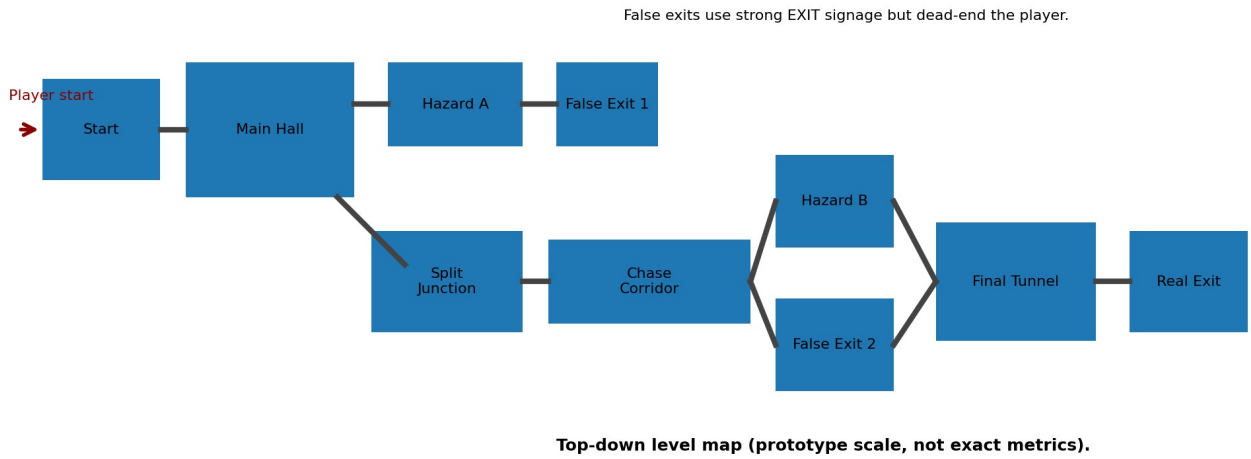

Figure 3. Top-down level map for prototype blockout.

6. Challenges & Rewards

Encounters

- Monster pursuit encounter: the creature stays behind the player pressure line and punishes hesitation.
- Fake exit encounter: the player receives false relief, then must recover quickly when the route fails.

Hazards

- Falling debris that blocks short paths or forces a quick lane change.
- Rising obstacles that punish straight-line running.
- Moving blockers that create rhythm-based dodge moments in narrow spaces.

Decision Challenges

- Choose the safer-looking path or the faster path under monster pressure.

- Read whether an EXIT door is a true progression point or a trap route.
- Balance speed against awareness; panic is dangerous, but stopping is worse.

Rewards

- Relief and progression after each correctly read route.
- Strong emotional payoff at the real exit.
- Clear introduction to the game's core tension loop for future levels.

7. Player Guidance, Readability & Fairness

- Fake exits must look believable, but should not use the same full visual language as the real exit. The real exit should have the cleanest silhouette and the strongest contrast.
- Hazards must telegraph with motion, sound, or light before impact. Surprise is allowed; unreadable failure is not.
- The level should use repeated visual logic: important turns get stronger light, dead-end pressure spaces get more clutter, and the true route gets cleaner framing.

8. Beat-by-Beat Walkthrough

Beat	Space	Player experience	Design purpose
1	Start Chamber	Short orientation and first tension	Give the player the objective with minimal delay.
2	Main Hall	Read the first major route and hear the threat	Teach space reading before the monster fully commits.
3	Hazard Zone A	Make the first active dodge	Introduce movement pressure.
4	False Exit 1	False relief, then disappointment	Teach that exits can lie.
5	Split Junction	Fast route choice under stress	Test reading under pressure.
6	Chase Corridor	Maximum pressure	Create the strongest intensity spike.
7	False Exit 2 / Hazard B	Punish panic, reward adaptation	Make the player recover from a wrong read.
8	Final Tunnel / Real Exit	Last sprint and release	Deliver payoff and transition.

9. Playtesting Plan & Results

Testing Questions

- Did players understand the main goal quickly?
- Did the chase feel tense but still fair?
- Could players identify the level's route logic after one or two failures?
- Were fake exits frustrating in a good way, or simply annoying?
- Did the final escape feel satisfying?

Summary of Early Test Results

Early test feedback showed that players liked the atmosphere and understood the horror intention quickly. The main issue was not the chase itself, but route readability during high stress. The first fake exit worked well, but the second fake exit was too visually similar to the real exit and felt unfair.

Changes Made After Testing

- Increased contrast and framing around the real exit so it reads as a stronger final goal.
- Added clearer hazard telegraphs in Hazard Zone B.
- Reduced clutter at one key junction so players could parse the route more quickly.
- Adjusted the timing of one moving blocker to reward reaction instead of blind memorization.

Simple Results Chart

Test point	Result	Action taken
Goal readability	Good	Kept opening objective simple.
Monster pressure	Good	No major change needed.
Fake Exit 1	Strong	Kept current setup.
Fake Exit 2	Too harsh	Improved visual distinction and route recovery.
Hazard Zone B	Mixed	Improved telegraph and timing.

10. Final Notes

This level is intentionally small in scope. Its job is not to tell a large story, but to teach the player's relationship with fear, movement, false information, and spatial trust. If the player reaches the real exit feeling relieved, tense, and curious to see what comes next, the level succeeds.